him for leave. Instead, he would call you and ask you to get ready to proceed on leave and to get the train or air reservations done. Perhaps the fact that he had suffered on this account made him more sympathetic to our welfare. There was a lot to learn from him.

When I joined, the Bde HQ was at Nagaon, Assam, with the Bn HQ at Kathiatali, a small village on the Nagaon–Doboka–Lumding road. The Companies were strung out along this road, including a Company for the protection of the Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL) terminal at Lumding. We carried out a number of operations here, with some success, neutralizing a dreaded ULFA cadre known as *Hath Kata* since he had only one arm. A couple of months after I reached, just as the CO was preparing to go on leave, orders came for us to move to the Kokrajhar district of Assam where the NDFB had carried out a massacre in one of the relief camps. I took the advance party and left, driving all the way from Kathiatali to Kokrajhar with Veena in tow, who had just joined the previous evening. The drive was surreal. We drove from Kathiatali via Jagiroad to Guwahati, crossing over to the North of the Brahmaputra, then via Rangia (HQ of 21 Mountain Division) through Barpeta and Bongaigaon to Kokrajhar, which we reached late in the evening. Except for these towns, the countryside was absolutely devoid of any habitation. No *dhabas* or restaurants, no STD/PCO booths or anything like that. And toilets? Just forget it. Just miles and miles of roads, with waterlogged paddy fields on either side. We established the Bn HQ at Sidli, in a public health centre (PHC) complex that was not in use. The Companies were located in the vicinity of likely flashpoints, including one at a place called Ultapani. Once that was done, Col Agarwal could finally proceed on his well-earned but much-delayed leave.

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